

Financial Success Checklist

A practical guide to building confidence with money—one step at a time.



Created by Leigh Grant Financial

For educational purposes only. This is not a recommendation to buy or sell any investment. Programs and eligibility vary by circumstance and jurisdiction. Review current official information or seek qualified advice before making decisions.



FOUNDATION • BUDGETING

Build your foundation

Every other part of your financial house rests here. A **budget** is simply a plan for where your money goes before you spend it.

Income is money coming in—pay, allowances, student funding. **Essential expenses** are costs you can't easily skip: rent, groceries, transit, phone. Whatever is left is where your choices live.

Watch bank fees. Monthly account fees and transaction charges add up. Many banks offer student or no-fee accounts—compare before you open one.



Money in

Pay, part-time work,
student funding



Money out

Essentials first, then wants



Set aside

Goals and your emergency
fund—even a small amount

Foundation checklist

- ☐ List every source of monthly income
- ☐ Review one month of spending
- ☐ Check what your bank account costs you
- ☐ Set one short-term goal with a date
- ☐ Automate a small transfer to savings on payday

TRY IT

My monthly income

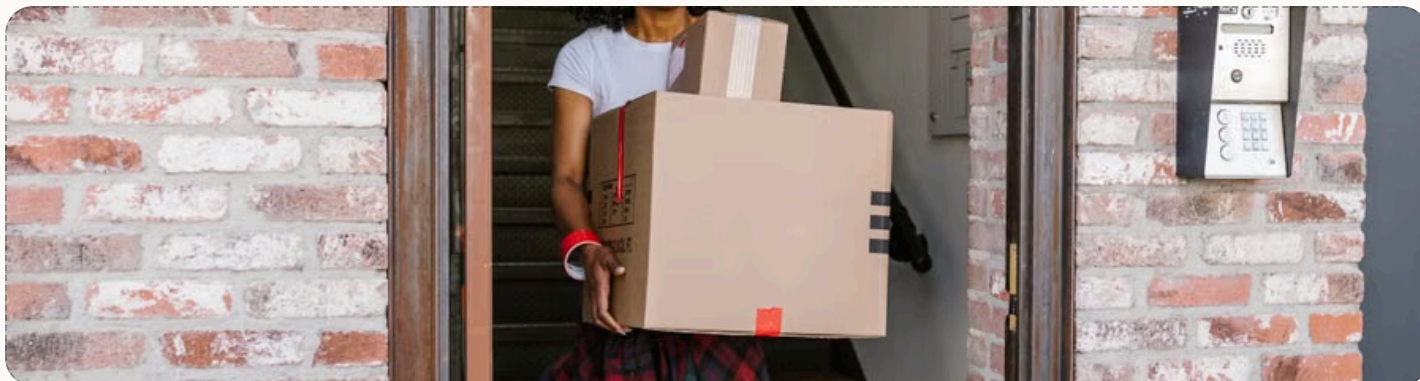
My essential costs

One change I can make this month

RISK MANAGEMENT · ESTATE · EMERGENCY FUND · PROTECTION

Prepare for the unexpected

A laptop dies, a roommate moves out, a shift gets cut. A safety net turns a crisis into an inconvenience.



Emergency fund

Cash kept separate for surprises. Start small—a first goal could be one unexpected bill. Common homes: a savings account, **GICs** or term deposits (locked in for a set time), or money market funds.

Income & asset protection

Know what covers you: school or workplace health and dental plans, **tenant insurance** for your belongings and liability, and—later—disability, life and critical illness coverage.

Estate basics

At 18+, a **will** and a **power of attorney** (someone to manage money if you can't) are worth learning about. Some provinces, like B.C., also use representation agreements for health decisions.

My first safety net

- ☐ Open a separate savings account for emergencies
- ☐ Pick a starter amount I can actually reach
- ☐ Check my health, dental and tenant coverage
- ☐ Get life, critical illness and disability insurance
- ☐ Turn on two-factor login for bank and email
- ☐ Store ID, SIN and key documents safely
- ☐ Name a trusted person who knows where they are

SPOT THE SCAM

Urgent pressure to pay *right now*

Payment by gift card, crypto or e-transfer to a stranger

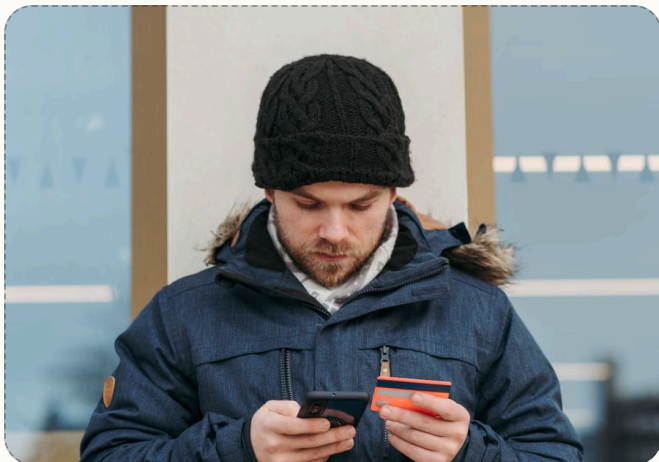
Requests for passwords or one-time codes

"Too good to be true" jobs or rentals

Pause. Contact the organization using a number you find yourself.

DEBT REDUCTION • BOOKKEEPING & TAX

Use credit without losing control



Credit cards, student loans and lines of credit all let you borrow now and repay later—usually with **interest**, the cost of borrowing.

The **minimum payment** keeps your account in good standing, but rarely clears the debt quickly. Paying by the **due date** protects your credit history.

Being *able to borrow* for something is not the same as being able to afford it. Ask how—and when—you'll pay it back.

SAME STATEMENT, TWO CHOICES

Pay the full statement balance

Balance goes to zero. On most cards, no interest is charged on purchases. Next month starts fresh.

Pay only the minimum

The rest carries over and interest is added. Next month you owe more than you spent.

Before I borrow

- ☐ What is the interest rate, and is it fixed?
- ☐ When does repayment start?
- ☐ What happens if I miss a payment?
- ☐ Does the payment fit my budget today?
- ☐ Set up autopay for at least the minimum

Bookkeeping & tax

Filing a tax return—even with low income—can be required to access some benefits and credits.

- ☐ Keep slips: T4 (work), T2202 (tuition)
- ☐ Track side-gig income and expenses
- ☐ Note the filing deadline in my calendar

ASSET MANAGEMENT · SAVINGS, RETIREMENT & INVESTMENTS

Start investing with the right account

Think of an **account** as the container and **investments** as what you put inside. The account decides the tax rules; the investments decide the risk and potential growth.

Each account has its own eligibility rules and contribution limits. Check what applies to you before you open one.



TFSA — Tax-Free Savings Account. Growth and withdrawals aren't taxed; use it for any goal.

RRSP — Registered Retirement Savings Plan. Contributions may lower taxable income; taxed when withdrawn.

RDSP — Registered Disability Savings Plan, for people eligible for the disability tax credit.

Non-registered account — no special tax treatment or contribution limit; investment income and gains are generally taxable. Often used once registered options are in place.

FHSA — First Home Savings Account, for eligible first-time buyers. Contributions may be deductible; qualifying home withdrawals are tax-free.

RESP — Registered Education Savings Plan. Saves for school; may receive Canada Education Savings Grants.

Workplace pension — Employer plans; some match what you contribute. Later, an RRSP may become a RRIF.

What can go inside

Cash & high-interest savings

GICs

Bonds

Mutual funds

Segregated funds

ETFs (exchange-traded funds)

Individual stocks

How to get started

- ☐ Have a starter emergency fund in place
- ☐ Pay down high-interest debt first
- ☐ Name my goal and when I'll need the money
- ☐ Check my eligibility and contribution room
- ☐ Understand how much risk I can handle
- ☐ Compare fees before choosing investments
- ☐ Open an account with a registered firm or advisor
- ☐ Automate a regular contribution

THE ROOF · FUTURE CHOICES & INDEPENDENCE

Map your next 12 months



With a steady budget, a safety net, credit under control and your first investments working, you're building toward the roof: a first home, more education, and the freedom to choose.

Here's a simple plan for the year ahead.

This week

Review last month's spending

Check bank fees

This month

Start a cash buffer

Identify education funding

This school term

Understand my borrowing terms

File my tax return

After graduation

Plan loan repayment

Review workplace benefits

Learn saving & investing basics

My next three money moves

MOVE

PRINT & FILL IN

BY WHEN

1

2

3

You don't need to have it all figured out. You need a place to start.

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